

# The 4-Way Debt Payoff Cheat Sheet

Four ways to attack debt, explained in plain English — no spreadsheet required to read this part. Pick the one you'll actually stick with, or use the 3-question guide below.

## Snowball

Pay minimums on everything, throw every extra dollar at your **smallest balance** first. Once it's gone, roll that payment into the next-smallest.

**Best for: momentum & motivation — fastest visible wins.**

## Avalanche

Same idea, but target your **highest-interest-rate** debt first instead. Mathematically the cheapest path — less total interest paid.

**Best for: people who trust the math over the mood.**

## Credit Score Focus

Target whichever card is closest to hurting your score — usually the one with the **highest utilization** (balance ÷ limit).

**Best for: anyone about to apply for a mortgage/car loan.**

## Your Own Order

Rank debts however matters to you — a card that stresses you out, one tied to a person, whatever. Your rules.

**Best for: when a formula doesn't capture what matters.**

### Not sure which one? Ask yourself, in order:

1. **Do I need a quick win to stay motivated?** → Snowball.
2. **Am I about to apply for credit, or is my score the priority right now?** → Credit Score Focus.
3. **Neither — I just want to pay the least amount of interest, period?** → Avalanche.
4. **None of these quite fit my situation?** → Your Own Order.

### THE REVEAL NO ONE ELSE OFFERS

## What if your spreadsheet told YOU the payment?

Most debt trackers only work one direction — you pick a payment, it tells you a date. **Cents of Direction** also works backward: type the date you want to be debt-free, and it solves the exact extra payment that gets you there — live, on screen. Plus a real sandbox that compares all three methods above side by side, for your real numbers, before you commit to a plan.

[See Cents of Direction →](#)